

By What Authority?

What political philosophy can teach us about
authority, legitimacy, and power inside
organizations

I studied political science in college, not business.

This did not seem especially relevant when I started working in customer service at Amazon. I was not contemplating the nature of sovereignty while answering emails about missing packages. But the further I got into the work, the more often that old vocabulary followed me.

Writing customer service policies felt suspiciously like writing legislation. A policy establishes a general rule that hundreds of people will apply to circumstances its author never anticipated. The obvious cases are easy. Then the edge cases arrive, and someone has to decide whether a situation falls within the rule, deserves an exception, or exposes a flaw in the rule itself.

Kaizens felt familiar too. Put people from several functions in a room with a shared problem and you will discover very quickly that agreeing on the problem is not the same thing as agreeing on what should be done about it. Finance wants costs controlled, Support wants less customer effort, Engineering wants stability, Product wants adoption, and the people doing the work would generally prefer not to be driven insane by it. Everyone can sincerely want the company to succeed and still disagree about what success requires.

Fifteen years later, I have come to think management is much more political than most management literature admits.

I do not mean partisan, and I definitely do not mean that every support team needs a bicameral legislature. I mean political in the older sense: people with overlapping but different interests trying to accomplish things together, deciding who gets to make which decisions, determining what makes those decisions legitimate, and figuring out what happens when people stop cooperating.

A corporation is not a state, a manager is not a sovereign, and an employee is not a citizen. Employment also involves economic dependence that makes any analogy to political consent imperfect from the start. Still, formal authority does not guarantee cooperation, and that fact becomes difficult to unsee once you have managed people.

An employee has considerable control over how seriously they engage with coaching, how much judgment they exercise, and whether they surface an emerging problem or give you the benefit of the doubt when a decision is ambiguous. Cross-functional partners control information and resources you may need but cannot command. Customers can simply leave. Your own authority continues only as long as someone above you delegates it.

A manager can possess authority while having very little practical power, or possess both while having almost no legitimacy. That last condition is where organizations get extremely weird.

Political philosophers have been arguing about variations of this problem for centuries.

Christopher McMahon makes the connection explicit in *Authority and Democracy: A General Theory of Government and Management*. He treats government and management as components of a broader system of social authority and asks how authority can enable cooperation among people whose aims differ.¹

I encountered McMahon long after I encountered the problem. Hobbes, Locke, Rousseau, and Arendt got there first.

Hobbes: Why Somebody Has to Be in Charge

Thomas Hobbes begins with a coordination problem.

His state of nature is a condition without a commonly recognized authority capable of settling disputes and enforcing decisions. The famous result is life that is “solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short.”² The stakes in a customer support organization are somewhat lower, but the mechanism is still recognizable.

Imagine a support organization where every agent invents their own workflows, Product releases features without telling Support, Operations optimizes entirely for cost, Engineering prioritizes whatever it considers important, and Sales makes promises nobody else knows about. Nobody has to be stupid or even selfish for this organization to become dysfunctional. Local rationality does not automatically produce collective rationality.

If you have ever attended a sufficiently dysfunctional cross-functional meeting, you already understand Hobbes.

This is the problem managerial authority solves. Someone has to establish standards, determine priorities, and decide between legitimate competing interests when agreement fails. Even a Boy Scout troop needs a scout leader.

McMahon makes cooperation central to authority for much the same reason. Large groups cannot function by individually persuading every participant about every decision; at some point, collective action requires recognized decision rights.³

That is a real function of management, and management criticism sometimes understates it. Organizations need authority, accountability, and standards that actually mean something. Endless consensus-seeking can become its own kind of dysfunction when every participant can effectively veto action simply by continuing to disagree.

But the moment authority exists, it creates another temptation: the person holding it can begin to treat the preservation of authority as the objective.

I have worked with managers who seemed to evaluate decisions partly by how completely the decision demonstrated that they were in charge. A process was successful because everyone followed it, a meeting was successful because nobody challenged the conclusion, and a team was well run because the manager had the final word.

Authority exists because coordination is necessary. Coordination does not exist so that someone can experience having authority.

That reversal causes an astonishing amount of organizational nonsense.

Locke: The Authority Beneath the Authority

John Locke complicates the picture.

Where Hobbes emphasizes the need for common authority, Locke grounds legitimate political authority in consent. In the *Second Treatise*, he argues that people who are naturally free cannot be subjected to political power without their consent.⁴

Employees obviously do not stand in the same relationship to managers that citizens stand in to governments. A company can assign me a manager without conducting a constitutional convention in the break room. But Locke points toward something management theory frequently misses.

There are really two structures operating inside an organization. One is the visible hierarchy through which authority is delegated from executives to directors, managers, and teams. Underneath it is a less visible structure composed of people continually deciding how much cooperation, information, judgment, credibility, patience, and trust they are willing to contribute.

A manager may have the formal right to direct my work, but they cannot compel genuine candor or order me to trust their judgment. They can require me to attend the meeting; they cannot require me to care whether the meeting succeeds.

This is why organizations can look healthy on paper long after something important has gone wrong. An employee can complete every assignment, acknowledge every coaching note, follow every procedure, and quietly stop contributing the things that made them valuable. They stop volunteering ideas, warning you early, or telling you that the process everybody is congratulating themselves on is broken. Eventually they give the organization exactly what the organization has demonstrated it deserves: the minimum.

The hierarchy survives while the cooperation underneath it erodes.

I saw the opposite happen while building a knowledge management system at Fully.

When I started, much of the team's institutional knowledge lived in a Microsoft OneNote maintained according to one person's organizational logic. Other experienced agents had their own macro libraries, private documents, favorite phrasing, and pieces of operational knowledge that had never made it into anything official.

I did not initially have formal authority over knowledge management, but I did need all that knowledge, so I asked people for it.

We audited the existing material, kept what worked, discarded what was outdated, and identified what was missing. I asked agents what language actually worked in difficult customer conversations, while subject-matter experts helped identify gaps and errors. We created consistent naming conventions and a searchable structure, and documentation gradually stopped being something produced somewhere above the team and handed down to them. Their fingerprints were on it.

Eventually I got the title and formal ownership of the system. That mattered because it made decisions faster and gave the work organizational legitimacy, but the title did not create the system's usefulness. The relationships did.

I filed all of this under change management at the time. I think now that something more interesting was happening: people were more willing to participate in a system that recognized their knowledge and gave them some authorship over the result. The org chart granted authority; participation created another kind of legitimacy.

Rousseau: The Dashboard Says Everyone Agrees

Jean-Jacques Rousseau is useful whenever managers become overly impressed by obedience.

In *The Social Contract*, Rousseau attacks the idea that superior force somehow becomes legitimate authority. His discussion of the "right of the strongest" distinguishes the ability to compel obedience from a right to obedience.⁵ Organizations rarely involve muskets or eighteenth-century sovereigns, but they do involve performance reviews.

Managers control assignments, schedules, development opportunities, promotions, ratings, disciplinary processes, and sometimes continued employment. Employees are aware of this arrangement.

So imagine that I introduce a new workflow and, thirty days later, the dashboard says adoption is 100 percent.

Wonderful. What have I learned?

Maybe the team understands why the change was necessary and believes it will help. Maybe they disagree but trust my judgment, or think the process is mediocre but consider the decision-making process fair. They may also think it is catastrophically stupid and have correctly concluded that refusing to use it will hurt their performance reviews.

The dashboard says **100%** in every version of this story.

Observable compliance is an extraordinarily weak measure of legitimacy.

I learned this the annoying way.

At Fully, I became concerned that agents were asking questions in Slack without checking whether answers already existed in our knowledge base. If every question became another one-off conversation, documentation would never become the default source of truth. So I created a rule: before asking for help, agents needed to demonstrate that they had searched the knowledge base.

My objective made sense. The mechanism irritated people.

At first, it was tempting to interpret the irritation as resistance to good process. I had built the documentation. They needed to use it. Please consult the magnificent system I have lovingly constructed for you.

Unfortunately, the resistance contained information.

Sometimes an article existed but was difficult to find. Sometimes the documentation answered the technical question and failed to answer the practical one. Sometimes nothing existed at all. A question in Slack could therefore be evidence that someone had failed to search, but it could just as easily be evidence that I had failed to build something searchable.

Those are very different diagnoses.

We changed the approach. Instead of requiring proof of research, we used the questions themselves to improve the system by linking existing articles, revising inadequate ones, and creating documentation where none existed. The employee asking the question stopped being treated as the last broken link in the process and became, sometimes, the sensor telling us where the process was broken.

That distinction matters because resistance is ambiguous. Someone may not understand a change, disagree with it, be protecting an interest the decision-maker has not properly weighed, or know something the

decision-maker does not. Formal authority makes these possibilities dangerously easy to collapse into one category: noncompliance.

Organizations reinforce the temptation because compliance is wonderfully measurable. We can track training completion, schedule adherence, workflow adoption, policy acknowledgment, and quality scores. Trust, legitimacy, and whether employees feel safe telling their manager something the manager does not want to hear are harder to put on a dashboard.

A management system can therefore become excellent at measuring obedience while becoming progressively worse at noticing that cooperation is disappearing.

And this is where the org chart begins to fail us.

Hobbes gives us a reason somebody needs authority. Locke shows how much cooperation still depends on other people. Rousseau warns us that obedience tells us very little about why they are cooperating. By this point, asking whether the manager's authority is legitimate is no longer enough.

There is a more fundamental question underneath it.

Where is the power?

This is where Hannah Arendt changes the picture.

Arendt: The Org Chart Is a Terrible Map of Power

Arendt gives us a startlingly different place to look.

Power, in her account, is not primarily a possession held by an individual. It arises among people when they act together.⁶

Take that idea seriously inside an organization and the familiar picture starts to wobble.

Suppose I am a CX manager redesigning an escalation process. On paper, I own the project. In practice, I need agents to use the process, trainers to teach it, QA to evaluate it, Operations to resource it, Product and Engineering to respond to what it reveals, and executives to continue supporting the work. Eventually, customers have to respond to the resulting experience in a way that makes any of this worthwhile.

I control a fraction of that.

An org chart might reduce the relationship to **Manager** → **Agent**, but reality is a network of dependencies among agents, customers, Product, Engineering, Operations, leadership, and everyone else whose cooperation

makes the outcome possible. Every relationship carries some mixture of information, negotiation, credibility, trust, incentives, and history.

That is where the work happens.

I have known people with almost no formal authority who could move an organization because everyone trusted their judgment. They knew the history behind decisions everyone else thought were arbitrary, understood who needed to be involved, and could translate between teams that struggled to talk to one another. I have also known managers with substantial formal authority whose influence ended almost exactly where their ability to compel compliance ended.

Arendt makes that difference legible.

Once power is understood as something produced through collective action, stakeholder management stops looking like the soft activity surrounding the important work and becomes part of the mechanism through which important work happens. Listening gives me access to information I do not possess, persuasion gets cooperation from people I cannot command, compromise allows legitimate interests to coexist, and trust covers the enormous territory no policy can specify in advance.

None of this requires endless consensus. Managers still have to make unpopular decisions, enforce standards, and resolve conflicts that cannot satisfy everyone. But once we understand how much organizational power exists between people rather than inside titles, the manager’s job looks different.

The manager sits inside several relationships simultaneously:

Constituency	What the manager needs	Disengagement or resistance can look like
Agents	judgment, candor, discretionary effort, trust	minimal compliance, silence, disengagement, turnover
Cross-functional partners	information, cooperation, resources	delays, deprioritization, information hoarding
Customers	continued exchange and trust	complaints, churn, reduced spending
Senior leaders	delegated authority and confidence	intervention, reduced scope, replacement

Those relationships also constrain one another. A manager can earn praise from senior leadership by reducing labor costs until the workload becomes intolerable, preserve popularity with employees by refusing to enforce legitimate standards, or satisfy customers through concessions that eventually make serving them uneconomical.

There is no configuration in which everybody simply gets what they want.

That is why management is political. The job involves negotiating among legitimate competing claims and maintaining enough cooperation among constituencies whose interests overlap without fully aligning.

McMahon's theory of managerial authority feels much less abstract from this vantage point. His argument that managerial authority facilitates cooperation among people with differing aims describes something managers encounter constantly.⁷

The shared goal is easy: "We want the company to succeed." The politics begin when we have to decide what success requires, what gets prioritized, what gets sacrificed, whose risk matters most, and who absorbs the cost.

A Brief Detour to Runnymede

Perhaps every support organization needs a Magna Carta.

I have worked in a few where I would have entertained the proposal.

The actual Magna Carta should not be romanticized. The 1215 charter emerged from a political crisis between King John and rebellious barons, and much of it concerned distinctly feudal grievances rather than modern democratic rights.⁸ Its historical afterlife nevertheless gave durable expression to an important idea: authority itself can be subject to rules.

Which raises one of the oldest problems in politics: who governs the governor?

Inside organizations, accountability travels downward with remarkable efficiency. Managers set expectations, evaluate performance, document mistakes, deliver coaching, and decide whether someone is meeting the standard.

What constrains the manager?

There are policies, senior leaders, HR departments, employment law, budgets, and performance reviews of their own. But enormous amounts of day-to-day managerial behavior happen inside a wide zone of discretion. Nobody sits in every one-on-one or hears the tone of every coaching conversation, and no policy can be comprehensive enough to govern every small exercise of managerial judgment.

That is why self-accountability matters so much.

If I expect employees to acknowledge mistakes and accept feedback, information needs a route in the opposite direction. If I expect transparency, I should explain decisions when explanation is possible. If I ask people to put organizational interests above their own preferences, they need some evidence that I am willing to apply the same standard to myself.

Otherwise accountability becomes something the hierarchy does to people beneath it, and authority begins consuming its own legitimacy.

This is one reason I have always been suspicious of managers who reach for the title itself when challenged. “I’m the manager,” “this is my decision,” and “you don’t have to agree” can all be formally true while also indicating that something else has gone wrong. Every time hierarchy has to become the argument for cooperation, the manager is spending a resource much harder to replenish than authority: credibility.

The strongest organizations cannot operate through continuous coercion, and neither can states. The enforcement costs would be absurd. Both depend on enormous amounts of ordinary cooperation happening because people broadly trust the system, understand its norms, recognize some legitimacy in its procedures, or simply have enough experience of reciprocity to believe that cooperation usually works.

Authority helps make that coordination possible.

Legitimacy makes it cheaper.

The Consent of the Managed

Fifteen years after I stopped studying political theory formally, I keep returning to its oldest questions: Who should have authority, what justifies it, why should someone cooperate with a decision they would not have made themselves, and what obligations come with the right to make decisions that affect other people?

The stakes inside a CX organization are obviously different from those of government, but the questions still feel familiar.

Most meaningful things I have accomplished as a manager required cooperation from people over whom I had incomplete, indirect, or absolutely no authority. Even my direct reports controlled things I needed and could never fully demand: judgment, candor, creativity, patience, discretionary effort, and trust.

That changed how I understand leadership.

Formal authority matters. Organizations need defined decision rights, accountability, standards, escalation paths, and some mechanism for ending disagreements that cannot continue forever. But an org chart tells us surprisingly little about how much power someone can actually exercise. It tells us who can decide, but it does not tell us who is trusted, knowledgeable, persuasive, or who controls the resources the team needs most to reach its goals.

Political philosophy gave me language for something I first learned at work. Hobbes explains why authority becomes necessary when individual interests need coordination. Locke reminds us that authority is never the whole relationship. Rousseau makes obedience a poor substitute for legitimacy. Arendt reveals how much power emerges in the space between people rather than descending neatly through hierarchy. McMahon brings those ideas directly into management and asks what legitimate managerial authority looks like when cooperation itself is the thing authority exists to make possible.

I did not expect any of this to follow me into customer support, but it did. Writing policies raised questions about rules, discretion, interpretation, and unintended consequences; process improvement meant negotiating among constituencies; organizational change raised questions about participation and legitimacy; and management forced me to think about where authority comes from, what it can accomplish, what constrains it, and how quickly its practical value collapses when the people around it stop cooperating.

An org chart can assign authority.

Power is something an organization has to keep creating together.

And that is a political problem.

Notes

1. Christopher McMahon, *Authority and Democracy: A General Theory of Government and Management* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1994). McMahon treats government and management as components of an integrated structure of social authority and examines managerial authority partly through its role in facilitating cooperation among people with differing aims.
2. Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan*, rev. student ed., ed. Richard Tuck (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), chap. 13.
3. McMahon, *Authority and Democracy*.
4. John Locke, *Two Treatises of Government*, student ed., ed. Peter Laslett (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988), Second Treatise, §95.
5. Jean-Jacques Rousseau, *The Social Contract and Other Later Political Writings*, ed. and trans. Victor Gourevitch (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997), bk. 1, chap. 3.
6. Hannah Arendt, *The Human Condition*, 2nd ed. (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1998), 200–201.
7. McMahon, *Authority and Democracy*.
8. UK Parliament, “Magna Carta,” accessed September 30, 2026.

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